PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep Comanche MJ

1986–1992 · MJ · Metric Ton · Eliminator

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Pull up the carpet**
  NAXJA and Comanche Club members agree: rust is the number-one issue, and unless the truck lived in the Southwest or Southern California, expect it in the floors. Rusty seat brackets or bolts usually mean rusty floor pans below.
- [ ] **Check where the cab meets the bed, and the rails**
  Look hard where the bed meets the cab and where the unibody joins the rear frame. NAXJA members warn that bulging rail bottoms mean rust inside. Water also enters through the rear cab bulkhead and window; one member says more than one MJ has gone to the crusher because of it.
- [ ] **Look for cracks and old welds on the frame**
  Comanche Club members say to inspect the frame closely for cracks or signs of weld repair, especially on trucks that hauled or towed.
- [ ] **Bed, tailgate and taillights**
  These are MJ-only parts and hard to replace. A crushed bed side or a missing tailgate costs more and takes longer to fix than a tired engine.
- [ ] **Identify the rear axle**
  An oval cover usually means a Dana 35, and an angular, roughly hexagonal cover means a Dana 44, per NAXJA. A 1991–92 truck may have the Chrysler 8.25. Ask whether it's a Metric Ton truck; sellers often don't know.
- [ ] **Renix or HO?**
  1987–90 4.0s run Renix management, which stores no codes and is diagnosed with a multimeter. 1991–92 HO trucks have Chrysler's system and 190 hp. Both are good engines, but Renix trucks reward owners who like electrical troubleshooting.
- [ ] **Hydraulic clutch and fuse box**
  On manual trucks, check the clutch master cylinder. Comanche Club members warn a leak can drip brake fluid into the fuse box, which damages it.
- [ ] **2.5 or 4.0?**
  The 4.0 is the one to have. If you buy a 2.5, Comanche Club members suggest looking for a 4.10 or 4.56 axle ratio. The AX-4 and AX-5 gearboxes behind the 2.5 won't bolt up to a 4.0.

YEARS TO KNOW

1991	SWEET SPOT	Chrysler engine management replaces Renix; 4.0 'High Output' 190 hp; Chrysler 8.25 rear appears; no automatic with the 2.5. The 1991–92 HO is the one to buy: easier to diagnose than the Renix 4.0, which is why Off Road Xtreme recommends the HO in the XJ that shares the engine

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Fuel line fitting**
  1986 · NHTSA 85V-139
- [ ] **Certification label ratings**
  1986 · NHTSA 86V-031
- [ ] **Accelerator cable bushing**
  1986 · NHTSA 86V-146
- [ ] **Parking brake pawl**
  1986 · NHTSA 86V-147
- [ ] **Steering linkage couplers**
  1986–1987 · NHTSA 86V-159
- [ ] **Intake-manifold stud chafing fuel hose**
  1987 · NHTSA 86V-160
- [ ] **Cruise control module**
  1987 · NHTSA 87V-022
- [ ] **Throttle body tolerance**
  1987 · NHTSA 87V-035
- [ ] **Brake booster vacuum reservoir**
  1986–1987 · NHTSA 88V-106
- [ ] **Throttle position sensor high idle**
  1989–1990 · NHTSA 90V-177

- [ ] **Metric Ton package**
  Long-bed only: heavier leaf springs, wheels and tires and a Dana 44 rear axle, rated at 2,205 lb payload. NAXJA members say to ask for it by name and confirm the Dana 44.
- [ ] **Rear axle cover**
  Per NAXJA, an oval cover usually means a Dana 35 and an angular, roughly hexagonal cover means a Dana 44. 1991–92 trucks may have the Chrysler 8.25 (Quadratec lists 27-spline 8.25 lockers for them). Offroaders lists an AMC 20 as a 1986 heavy-duty option.
- [ ] **Bed length**
  Short bed: 6 ft on a 113 in wheelbase (1987–92). Long bed: 7 ft on 119.9 in (1986–92). Per Comanche Club, the Eliminator, Chief and SporTruck were short-bed only and the Laredo long-bed only.
- [ ] **Renix or HO**
  1987–90 4.0s have Renix management; 1991–92 trucks are the 190 hp 'High Output' with Chrysler controls. 1986–87 grilles have ten slots and 1988–92 grilles eight.
- [ ] **VIN**
  NHTSA's free vPIC decoder reads MJ VINs, including drive type and bed length on early trucks. The tenth character is the model year (G = 1986 through N = 1992). AMC-era VINs start 1JT and Chrysler-era 1989–92 VINs start 1J7. Comanche Club keeps a VIN registry.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/comanche-mj/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks